



Graphic by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY

KOSI IN SPATE

Had timely action been taken, the catastrophe that devastated millions could have been averted

■ **Kosi breached the barrage side near Kusaha in Nepal**

■ **The silt that had deposited along the river's course from Nepal to Kursela in Bihar forced it to change the course**

■ **The river turned eastward this time because of massive sedimentation and the land tilt along its banks**

■ **As the weak embankment gave way, the Kosi river broke loose**

■ **The heavy siltation near Bhimnagar barrage only added to the disaster**

TROUBLED WATERS: Villagers carry all they can while fleeing Danapur

Nobody knows if the inmates have escaped or lost their lives to the fury of water. From Madhepura jail, 545 prisoners have been transferred to Saharsa. Sonbarsa MLA Kishore Kumar Munna told INDIA TODAY that he had seen hundreds of bodies including those of mothers with their dead children still clung to them. "Thousands have been swept away," he said.

Manoj Yadav, a farmer from Kuchcha Purab Tola of Kumarkhand block in Madhepura, who has taken shelter at a Saharsa relief camp with his family, confirmed having seen "dozens of bodies floating" while travelling in a hired boat. While no officials are willing to either confirm or deny the estimated casualties, the official death figures from

Kosi waters is nine. No wonder, Chief Minister Nitish Kumar has described the floods as "nothing less than a catastrophe". However, what he left unsaid is something that makes it even more ironic—the disaster has all the elements of man-made avoidable errors. According to the 1954 agreement (revised in 1966) reached between India and Nepal over the Kosi project, the construction, repair and maintenance of the barrage located in Nepal has been Bihar's responsibility for which the state is reimbursed by the Centre.

This year, the engineers had started the strengthening work, where a breach was officially recorded on August 18, but washed their hands off by registering an FIR against local Nepal residents who were creating hurdles in the repair work. One of the other major reasons that kept them from reaching the embankment of the Kosi near Kusaha was the threat from the Maoists. The Nepalese Police were also not willing to deal with the Maoists. But then, nobody had gauged the enormity of the threat and by the time they got their act together, the embankment was breached. In fact, the state Government on August 10 received a fax from Supaul District Magistrate Sharif Alam that conclusively said that the "situation was under control". A fortnight later, the state Government had to give marching orders to him and his Saharsa counterpart Garib Sahu for not taking timely action. Supaul Superintendent of Police Shyam Kumar too was shifted.



The official death toll given out by the Government is nine but an independent MLA from Sonbarsa says he has "seen the bodies of thousands that were swept away".